



TO THE
CITIES
I'VE
NEVER
KNOWN

"There is no place that is not haunted by many different spirits hidden there in silence, spirits one can "invoke" or not. Haunted places are the only ones people can live in—and this inverts the schema of the *Panopticon*. But like the gothic sculptures of kings and queens that once adorned Notre-Dame and have been buried for two centuries in the basement of a building in the rue de la Chaussee-d'Antin, these 'spirits,' themselves broken into pieces in like manner, do not speak any more than they see. This is a sort of knowledge that remains silent. Only hints of what is known but unrevealed are passed on 'just between you and me.'"

Michel de Certeau, *The Practice of Everyday Life* (translated by Steven Rendall)

TO THE CITIES I'VE NEVER KNOWN

Can we ever truly know a city?

By the time we believe we've distilled its essential nature—strained it out of that bright chaos of sensation and emotion—wouldn't it have morphed into something different?

What do we have but the stories we tell about them?

I love writing songs about *those* stories: the ones we tell about places, that become those places in time. I see it as one of the wonders of music, that we can conjure landscapes, scenes, and atmospheres with simple turns of melody and phrase.

To the Cities I've Never Known is a compilation of my favourite songs from the past two years. Some are about narrative and imagined worlds. Others are about cities that are hazy from years of distance; yet others are snapshots of scenes that now only exist in memory.

All of them are about the places that haunt me wherever I go. Enjoy!

- Circlejourney



THE FALL

Originally released on [Kindred Souls](#)
Art by Tavvy • [gem-tavvy.tumblr.com](#)

Undertale, am I right? I wrote this song for a 10th anniversary Undertale + Deltarune album. I won't repeat the full commentary here, but it's inspired by the interpretation of the Undertale intro where Frisk is on Mount Ebott for a suicide attempt.

I guess it is somewhat my style to take a dour, even ~edgy~ theme and turn it into an upbeat, optimistic song. I relate to that version of Frisk standing at the top of the mountain wondering if it would be better to end it all, who went on to help everyone else in the process.

Glad I could finally pay tribute to a game that has changed many lives. It was cathartic to lyrically portray the notion that you mean the world to far more people than you could possibly imagine.

Though it's hard, my dear, to play your part
With the execution blade in your hand
While a candle of hope lights your heart
No blood will wash the land
For the fear of all you couldn't be
You could never see the tale you'd begun
Though the fall was so lonely
Your love touched everyone

Halt right there
Now where have you been?
You were meant to meet the world
Either burn it or save it

The flowers lie in skies that roll forever
And remember
You can't cheat the world
Always returns what you give it

Daggers, staves and beggars
Maths and manners
Baths and banners on the wall
And meadows, masks and shadows
Bask in shallows
Play in the rain
Rise up again and gain
Royal, false or loyal
Pause and try all doors
Turn strangers into friends
And lovers, till flowers unfold the end

Though it's hard, my dear, to play your part
With the execution blade in your hand
While a candle of hope lights your heart
No blood will wash the land
For the fear of all you couldn't be
You could never see the tale you'd begun
Though the fall was so lonely
Your love touched everyone

Through the burning days and darkest nights
Hold your little dagger close in your hand
Let your candle of hope be your light
Your voice grieves the wasteland
Though you fear the things you cannot be
There's a world of love you've yet to see
Though the fall is so lonely
You'll live to tell the story

So take the leap and fall
When you hope and dream
It takes nothing at all
So fall
All it takes to save the world
Is start out small

And it's hard, I know, to play our parts
Throw the execution blade from your hand
While a hope still burns bright in our hearts
No blood will wash the land
For the fear of all you couldn't be
For the story that you've somehow begun
Though the fall was so lonely
Your love saved everyone

For the fear of all you cannot be
You could only dream of what you'll unfurl
Though the fall is so lonely
You'll rise to change the world

DOWN THE ROAD

Down the Road came to me in a dream where I was still a teen living in Singapore. In the dream, I was producing this song in FL Studio, and I listened to the chorus so many times that it was still stuck in my head when I woke up.

I'm a part-time country music aficionado; beyond the predilection for the major pentatonic scale and lyrics about mundane details of everyday life, I love the way many of them tell a story that gradually changes the meaning of a repeating chorus or refrain.

In hindsight, my love for such narrative songs heavily influenced my songwriting style, and that's probably why dream-me chose to make one in homage to that.

Remember our last day
Too much to do
Too much to say
Sat with you while you cried
And watched the clouds
As they rolled by

Then out of the blue
The horizon was calling our names
And I knew how to say my goodbye
So we jumped through the doors
And we rolled down the glass
With the sun on the floor
We watched the fields fly past

Whoa, yeah, long ago
We were driving down the road
Two fools years ago

Laughing 'bout how far we'd go
Now you've headed home
I am on the road alone and
Though you've left me
You're with me wherever I go
Wherever I go

The letter came ten years on
So many words, but all they meant
was, "we're seeing off your old friend
Bring flowers, we'll see you then"
So I cried myself sore
'Cause your warmth was no more
And I sat by the door
With the sun in my eyes
And the moment I saw
How the clouds carried on rolling by
I recalled the day we said goodbye

Whoa, yeah, long ago
We were driving down the road
Two fools years ago
Laughing 'bout how far we'd go
You said, "Don't you cry,
This is not our last goodbye,"
And though you've left me
You're with me where'er I go

Whoa, yeah, long ago
We were driving down the road
Just two friends years ago
Laughing 'bout how far we'd go
And now you've headed home
I am on the road alone
And though you've left me
You're with me wherever I go
Wo-o-oah



HAUNTSONG

Written for NECROTREATRE's [House of Haunts](#)

First verse lyrics: NECROTREATRE ([toyhou.se/NECROTREATRE](#))

Art by SketchyCC ([toyhou.se/SketchyCC](#))

Hauntsong began as a 6-instrument song for NECROTREATRE, but I always felt like the composition was suited to a full orchestral piece, so I went ahead and expanded the instrumentation.

House of Haunts tells the story of a cook-for-hire who joins the titular house and becomes trapped in a game where newcomers must face a new opponent every night, either defeating them or being fed to...whatever lives in the pit. It's eerie, it's gay, it has astronomical symbolism. Various lines here reference the manor's many rooms and past inhabitants.

This song also has a visualiser animation courtesy of SketchyCC—check it out [here](#)!

(Hello?)

Where dreams come true, as walls flicker blue
A mask parades in the sky
It seems you're lost with the rest of us
And we welcome you to your first night
The moon grins down on our merry-go-round
No start and no end to this ride
Just pay the fare, come and play if you dare
You're in for the game of your life

Watch your back, red or black?
Face the dark and it will attack

Shed no tears, drown your fears
Nothing's as it appears
With the changing the light
Usher in the night, either
Eat or you'll be eaten, fight or flight
Chills run down your spine
Do you see the signs?
Will you tell your secrets before you die?

The moon grins down on our merry-go-round
No start and no end to this ride
Just pay the fare, come and play if you dare
You're in for the game of your life
'Cause where dreams come true, as walls flicker blue
A mask parades in the sky
It seems you're lost with the rest of us
And we welcome you to your first night

BIRD SONG

I don't know how much I've said about my plans to write an *Eagles and Swans* musical, but I've only ever released one other song under this concept: [*Memorialisation*](#).

Bird Song is the second. It was conceptualised as a character song for Hollia, a birdkeeper who inherited her job from her parents. (Hollia is also the character featured in the track art for [*Idyllic*](#).)

The introductory piano refrain and the line “How can you miss something you’ve never had?” have existed in my MIDI drafts since 2016 or so, but I never had any push to complete the song...

...until I had a dream about writing a four part vocal harmony that just happened to have the exact chords I had envisioned for *Bird Song*. I recorded it the minute I woke up and, just like that, the song fell together. First the piano draft, then the orchestral rendition.

Woah, wo-o-oah,
Wo-o-o-o-o-o-oah

Beat your wings, peck the bars
Tear out your feathers and scratch the stars
Of the world beyond, you see a shadow
Here there is all that a bird could want, though

What's this longing that lasts through every age?
What is calling you out beyond your cage?
What strange sorrow, so curious and glad
How you can miss something you've never had?
Wo-o-oah

String the nets, sweep the floor
Water the flowers and close the door
When the summer's flown, they try to follow
Sleep is a poison that holds them down, though

What's this longing that lasts through every age?
What is calling you out beyond your cage?
What strange sorrow, so curious and glad
How I can miss something I've never had?
Oo-oo-oooh,
O-oh, o-oh

This track doesn't have an illustration to go with it, but here's some art I've done of Hollia over the years.





WHEREVER YOU WERE

Guest vocals: Céleste Lenahan • pinkie.horse

Wherever You Were is a character song for Marin and Cielo, the deuteragonists of my webcomic *Compass* who spend the story sailing in search of the edge of the world. It was an absolute privilege to collab with Céleste on this; I sing Cielo's part and she sings Marin's.

Long before they meet, the two sense there's something they are searching for without knowing what it is. The lyrics gesture at the sense of déjà vu they have when they see each other for the first time in a port city.

Wherever You Were was initially released by itself, and I wrote [a big block of commentary](#) to accompany it. I'm so pleased with how it came out that I decided to rerelease it here with improved production.

All my life, I've sought a safer seashore
And felt like I wanted something more
Than to watch the days go by
What am I
Waiting here for?
I've passed from port to harbour
City by city, wanderer
Asking strangers if you're there
Going wherever you were

What is forecast? (Light by light, line by line, chart)
What's this glowing out at sea? (Sight by sight, sigh by sigh)
Calling out, a nameless (And port by port)
Voice from the past (Dream I had)

My future bliss waits there (That I forgot)
For me

What's this memory? (Light by light, line by line, chart)
What is gazing from the shore? (Sight by sight, sigh by sigh)
Calling out, a nameless (And port by port)
Voice from a dream (Dream I had)
A truth I miss (That I forgot)
Waits there for me

All my life, I've sought a safer seashore
And felt like I wanted something more
Than to watch the days go by
What am I
Waiting here for?

(Light by light)
I've passed from port (Line by line)
To harbour (Chart sight by sight)
City by city (Sigh by sigh, and)
Wanderer (Port by port, dream I had)
Asking strangers if you're there (That I forgot)
Going wherever you were

I'll sail without a crew
I'll find a way to weather through
Every circle, every end
I will bend
Time to find you

I'll sail without a crew
I'll find a way to weather through
Every circle, every end
I will bend
Time to find you

All my life (Light by light)
I've sought a safer (Line by line, chart)
Seashore (Sight by sight)
And felt like I wanted (Sigh by sigh, and)
Something more (Port by port, dream I had)
Than to watch the days go by (That I forgot)
What am I
Waiting here for?

(Light by light)
I've passed from port (Line by line)
To harbour (Chart sight by sight)
City by city (Sigh by sigh, and)
Wanderer (Port by port, dream I had)
Asking strangers if you're there (That I forgot)
Going wherever you were



NO WONDERLAND

Written for bonebark • toyhou.se/bonebark

Lyric ideation: bonebark

No Wonderland was written as a character song for bonebark's Justin Hallworth, a nightclub owner with more issues than the New York Times. The lyrics explore his turbulent life and the problems he's made a habit of ignoring.

This song continues to be one of my favourites, especially lyrically. Few things feel better than coming up with satisfying paired internal rhymes, and the song's slow tempo gave me room to sneak in a lot of these.

One AM, sitting with shadows
A face distorts in a bottle
Where will it leave me in the end?
One bad trip then another
Think of anything but her stare
As it fragments in my hand

I'd say these scars tell a story, I mean
I'm in the business of lying, to me
I might be the life of the party
With just one light
Truth is
Some days I couldn't be higher
Some days, they set me on fire
Some days I just wanna curl up and

Pull me under, yeah, pull me under
My friends all wonder
Where's the boy that they knew?
'Cause with every blunder
I have to wonder, can't I understand
This numb fantasy is no wonderland

Headache, cracked lips and red-eye
Another day I'm high and dry
Just a-lying on the floor
Falling apart since I was four
I draw the curtains, close the door
Can't hurt to have one more

Won't say what doesn't need knowing, but yeah,
Lines on my arms always showing
A map of places I have been going
Behind their backs
But then
All trains will terminate somewhere
All brains break down in the dead air
All veins go cold in a heart attack

Pull me under, yeah (One AM, sitting with shadows)
Pull me under (A face distorts in a bottle)
My friends all wonder (Where)
"Where's the boy that we knew?" (Will it leave me in the end?)
'Cause with every blunder (One bad trip then another)
I have to wonder, can't I understand (Think of anything but her stare as it
fragments)
This numb fantasy is no wonderland
Wo-oah

EQUATOR

I wrote *Equator* the day before I left on a trip back to Singapore, and it ended up being about that moment in time.

Usually, these kinds of songs are about escaping to a tropical paradise...so I wanted to subvert that aesthetic with lyrics that are instead about wanting to go home.

跟我一起看大海: come watch the ocean with me
海浪代表我的爱: the ocean waves symbolise my love

The latter line is structurally a nod to the titular line from 月亮代表我的心 (the moon symbolises my heart).

Is the summer hotter
On the far end of the sea?
Does the warmer water
Of the island long for me?
If I waded farther
Would the ocean set me free?
Waiting on a message in a bottle
To call me home and home I'll be

I've spent too long without a breeze
Shivering with the strangeness
Of coastlines without seas
Always I'm waiting to hear
The rush of salt and sand and trees
Oh please, I need see
Some blue to be at ease

So tell me
Is the summer hotter
On the far end of the sea?
Does the warmer water
Of the island long for me?
If I waded farther
Would the ocean set me free?
Waiting on a message in a bottle
To call me home and home I'll be

Rolling 'round the Ring of Fire
Spinning ocean gyres
Bring warmer waters
From where I wanna be
Weaving in between the islands
Bringing birds and garlands
Let's take the currents
Back home and home I'll be

Walk with me, one two and three
跟我一起看大海
Won't you walk with me, come see the sea
海浪代表我的爱
Walk with me, one two and three
You're the apple of my eye
Won't you walk with me, come see the sea
Bid the sun goodbye

Longing for the wide equator
Over the Pacific
The warmer waters
From where I wanna be
Weaving in between the islands
Bringing birds and garlands
Let's take the currents

Back home and home I'll be
(Two three)

So is the summer hotter (Rolling 'round the Ring of Fire)
On the far end of the sea? (Spinning ocean gyres)
Does the warmer water (The warmer waters)
Of the island long for me? (From where I want to be)
(Two three)
'Cause if I waded farther (Weaving in between the islands)
Would the ocean set me free? (Bringing birds and garlands)
Waiting on a message in a bottle (Let's take the currents)
To call me home and home I'll be (Back home and home I'll be)



...AND SCENE

Originally released on [Fondly Regard Illustration](#)

Samples *Zillow for Evil Lairs* by ghost-elevator • [ghost-elevator.tumblr.com](#)

Art by DDP • [disegnidipizzo.tumblr.com](#)

...and scene was inspired by the art piece by DDP (left) for the Unofficial MSPA Fans' *Fondly Regard Illustration*. (For that album, artists drew their illustrations first and then musicians created tracks based on them.)

The painting features Ardata from the Hiveswap Friendsim, a livestreamer who tortures trolls for her audience's entertainment. A completely sound way of coping with your problems if you ask me.

I wanted to hint at the disjoint of her on- and offscreen identities and the way the horror of her daily doings seep through the cracks in her facade, no matter the image she projects on camera.

O-o-o-oh

O-o-o-oh

O-o-o-oh

O-o-o-oh

What is there to say
That you haven't seen
I've put a picture perfect
portrait on your screen

Watch me bleed them dry
Hit that like and scream
I'm a wreck, I'm a ruin

I'm put together wrong
(...and scene)

O-o-o-oh
O-o-o-oh

So you think you know
Know just what I mean?
Well then enjoy the show
Make sure that I feel seen
Keep your eyes wide shut
Bow before the queen
I will make the final cut
I will be on the scene

(....and scene)

POSTCARD LULLABIES

Postcard Lullabies is the most biographical song on this album. Here I go inventing a spectrum of bigraphicality just for this album, but if the majority of these songs are a 1 – 3 on the scale, then *Equator* is a 7, and this one is a 10.

This song was originally intended to be the third track on my EP *Love Letters*, but for various reasons, it finds its home here instead.

I could go on for ages about all the significant details here, but the most important is the quote of *Interlude*, a song that (to my knowledge) is not publicly available to listen to and will likely remain that way. Unearthing the stems for that song in an old USB drive is what made *Postcard Lullabies* come to be.

(It is too late to say I knew
I would regret not coming through
Wasted chances, traded glances
Threatening to mean something half true)

It was the best of my life, the worst of my nevers
Was a fool, wasn't I, to want her for forever
Should've known when she said her future wasn't me
No, it was my ship to wreck

Have I become a regret, do I still haunt her fears?
Can't help thinking we had two very different years
And day glowered grey, although the sky was clear
Even now, I play it back

The way she said, "I'm out of love with you"

Four months later, she was seeing someone new
My soul still living on that golden seaside
Walking in the sunlight
I turn to keep her smile in my view
My heart forgot she said, "I'm out of love with you"
Four months later, she had faded out of view
Yet despite myself, I still recall the shape of her room
And the way she'd tell me, "I love you"

The wind unfolds on shores and shoals
And foam on sails of salt and whales
The vaulting sky as pale, as dry as heaven above
The sandy skies and dragonflies
And blazing eyes in paradise
A thousand postcard lullabies
To a place that doesn't exist anymore

(I know)
She's a dream from my past (The wind unfolds on shores)
I'd be lying if I said (And shoals, and foam)
That I want to return (On sails of salt)
To any part of that (And whales, the)
But if memories are graves then (Vaulting sky, as pale)
I'm dying in my bed (As dry as)
There are nights I lie with the dead (Heaven above)
(I know)
And I know (The sandy skies)
We're no longer the people we were then (And dragonflies, and)
I have fallen in love again and again (Blazing eyes in paradise, I'll write)
But I'm learning the heart takes a while (You postcard lullabies)
To forget the one it thought it had forever (My love)

She said, "I'm out of love with you"
Four months later, she was seeing someone new
My soul still living on that golden seaside

Walking in the sunlight
I turn to keep her smile in my view
My heart forgot she said, "I'm out of love with you"
Four months later, she had faded out of view
Still I keep a picture-perfect memory of her room
And the way she'd tell me, "I love you"



DREAMS AND WAKES

Originally released on [Fondly Regard Illustration](#)

Art by SelanPike • [epicyclestudios.com](#)

Dreams and Wakes is the second track on this album that was made for UMSPAF's *Fondly Regard Illustration*. This one was inspired by SelanPike's illustration of Problem Sleuth (main character from the comic of the same name) using his final attack Sepulchritude, rendered here in the Renaissance Piéta motif.

Dreams and Wakes aims to evoke the feel of transcendence and the deific themes of the comic scene and the art piece. Why does dreamy dancepop sounds like gods and angels to me? Not sure, I just rolled with it.

I had many candidates for the penultimate track, but of my repertoire from the past 2 years, this is perhaps the track I'm proudest of, and I wanted it in my public discography.

TIME KEEPS MARCHING

Guest vocals:

Ucklin • youtube.com/@ucklin8025

Waltz • koyoba.tumblr.com

As a teen, running away from home/school was how I coped with feeling like I wasn't enough. *Time Keeps Marching* speaks to that: the solace of vanishing into the unknown, the magnet-pull of home, the comfort of knowing it will pass. (It's probably a 5 on biographicality.)

The project was initially spliced together from two different drafts that happened to have the same chords and syncopated rhythm—one with the bells and strings, the other with the piano. I meant for it to be instrumental, but after a few listens I sensed a sparkle that compelled me to start singing lyrics over it.

I knew the layered sections needed multiple singers to distinguish the various voices. I'm incredibly grateful that I got to collaborate with Ucklin and Waltz and for how much their vocal talents add to the track!

I heard they saw you running away from home
Isn't it nice or something to be on your own
I know it's hard, my darling, to feel left behind
But something good is coming, you just have

To give it time, give it time to grow
Time, soon your roots will show
A little time always melts the snow
Time, let the future go

I heard they saw you running away from home

Isn't it nice, or something, to be on your own
I know it's hard, my darling, to feel left behind
But something good is coming, you just have
To take your time restarting, climb day by day
You may feel good for nothing, but nothing they say
Can change that time keeps marching and wipes away
The wound of every parting, come what may
Just give it time

In the endless gloom, light a flame
When the shadows loom, give them a name
Though you walked for years, no one came
Still your home waits here, always the same

In the endless gloom (I heard they saw you running)
Light a flame (Away from home)
When the shadows loom (Isn't it nice, or something)
Give them a name (To be on your own)
Though you walked for years (I know it's hard, my darling)
No one came (To feel left behind)
Still your home waits here (But something good is coming)
Always the same (You just have)
To give it time

Just give it time (I heard they saw you running)
Give it time to grow (Away from home)
Time (Isn't it nice, or something)
Soon your roots will show (To be on your own)
A little time (I know it's hard, my darling)
Always melts the snow (To feel left behind)
Time (But something good is coming)
Let the future go (You just have)

Just give it time (To give it time, my darling) (In the endless gloom)
Give it time to grow (Climb day by day) (Light a flame)

Time (You may feel good for nothing) (When the shadows loom)
Soon your roots will show (But nothing they say) (Give them a name)
A little time (Can change that time keeps marching) (Though you walked for years)
Always melts the snow (And wipes away) (No one came)
Time (The wound of every parting) (Still your home waits here)
Let the future go (Come what may) (Always the same)

Just give it time, give it time to grow
Time, soon your roots will show
A little time always melts the snow
Time, let the future go

[BONUS] LIGHT A FIRE

Written for DVRK • [x.com/DVRK_Team](https://twitter.com/DVRK_Team)

Lyric ideation: DVRK

Light a Fire is a theme song for *DVRK*, a visual novel in development. The story follows Kuro, a young man haunted by events of his past, and the friendships he forms amid his quest for revenge.

I tried to capture that sense of camaraderie in the midst of grief in this opening theme. I went for a J-rock feel (as directed), and I am pretty pleased at the bit of storytelling I achieved within its 2-minute runtime.

The official version has vocals by [Rachel K Lake](#); this is my rendition!

Light a fire
You hope will keep the cold away
All your ire
It burns, it burns down every doorway
Mad with sorrow
It haunts you though you try to run away
Where is tomorrow?
Is there any escape from today?

Turn from the light
To face a cruel memory
Chasing your ghosts
Are you the hunter or the prey?

Sometimes it's best
To leave the past where it lies
In the dark, every light
Looks like a phantom's burning eyes
Your grief looms so large
That it shades out the sunlight
But without the truth
Oh, can you tell what is wrong or right?

Light a fire
You hope will keep the cold away
All your ire
It burns, it burns down every doorway
Mad with sorrow
It haunts you though you try to run away
Where is tomorrow?
Is there any escape, will you ever escape?

Guard your fire
The cold is all you've known
Does your heart feel lighter
To know you're not alone?
In this world of sorrow
There's solace in the bonds you share
And come tomorrow
We'll be there, so

Light a fire
You hope will keep the cold away
All your ire
It burns, it burns down every doorway
Mad with sorrow
It haunts you though you try to run away
Where is tomorrow?
Is there any escape?

[BONUS] RAINY SUNDAY

Rainy Sunday was written in March 2025, while/about waiting for Tropical Cyclone Alfred to pass. I recorded the entire songwriting process, which you can watch on [YouTube](#).

From the first pitter patter
A flock, a flight, a chatter
Of birds that must know better
I feel the wind grow wetter
All through the streets a whisper
The rising southeaster
Turning the wind rose, there's
Something coming closer

Empty office calling
Twenty five and falling
Every boats a-moorings
Tidal forces shoring
Radiowaves are roaring
Word has started pouring in
They say we'll begin
Breath in, and

Bang, walls fall like paper
Wind swings skyscrapers
Watching radars, arrays of rain and vapour
Boom, a beach goes under
Shorelines shake with thunder

The gales will gather while we
Wait and wonder

All the trees are thrashing
Powerlines are lashing
Joining neighbours
To watch the lightning flashing
All alone together
Talking 'bout the weather
A rainy sunday that goes on forever

